

Linear Algebra and Calculus Lecture 14

Eric Sandin Vidal

Fall 2025

Dot Product

In this lecture we will define and work with the notion of length of a vector.

Definition. The **inner product** (or in this case, **dot product**) between two vectors $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$, written as $\langle \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \rangle$ (respectively, $\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v}$), is a real value given by ____, that is

$$\begin{bmatrix} u_1 & \cdots & u_n \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} v_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{bmatrix} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}.$$

Theorem. Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$ and $\mathbf{w}$ be vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$, and let c be a scalar. Then

1. $\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$
2. $(\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) \cdot \mathbf{w} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$
3. $(c\mathbf{u}) \cdot \mathbf{v} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$
4. $\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{u} \geq 0$, and $\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0$ if and only if $\underline{\hspace{2cm}}$

Definition. The **length** (or **norm**) of $\mathbf{v}$ is the nonnegative scalar $\|\mathbf{v}\|$ defined by

$$\|\mathbf{v}\| = \sqrt{\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} \quad \text{and} \quad \|\mathbf{v}\|^2 = \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v}.$$

Remark. This norm is what is called the Euclidean norm, but there are many other norms and ways to define length. In this course, we use Euclidean norms.

Remark. Notice that $\|c\mathbf{v}\| = |c|\|\mathbf{v}\|$.

A vector whose length is 1 is called a **unit vector**. If we divide a nonzero vector $\mathbf{v}$ by its length we obtain a unit vector $\mathbf{u}$ because the length of $\mathbf{u}$ is $(1/\|\mathbf{v}\|)\|\mathbf{v}\|$. The process of creating $\mathbf{u}$ from $\mathbf{v}$ is sometimes called **normalizing $\mathbf{v}$** , and we say that $\mathbf{u}$ is in the same direction as $\mathbf{v}$.

Definition. For $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$, the **distance** between $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$, written as $\text{dist}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$, is the length of the vector $\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}$. That is,

$$\text{dist}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}.$$

Consider $\mathbb{R}^2$ or $\mathbb{R}^3$ and two lines through the origin determined by vectors $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$. The two lines are geometrically perpendicular if and only if the distance from $\mathbf{u}$ to $\mathbf{v}$ is the same as the distance from $\mathbf{u}$ to $-\mathbf{v}$. This is equivalent to requiring the squares of the distances to be the same. Now,

$$\begin{aligned}\text{dist}(\mathbf{u}, -\mathbf{v})^2 &= \|\mathbf{u} - (-\mathbf{v})\|^2 \\ &= \|\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}\|^2 \\ &= (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) \cdot (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) \\ &= \mathbf{u} \cdot (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) + \mathbf{v} \cdot (\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}) \\ &= \mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v} \\ &= \|\mathbf{u}\|^2 + \|\mathbf{v}\|^2 + 2\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v}.\end{aligned}$$

Similarly, interchanging $\mathbf{v}$ and $-\mathbf{v}$ shows that

$$\begin{aligned}\text{dist}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})^2 &= \|\mathbf{u}\|^2 + \|\mathbf{v}\|^2 + 2\mathbf{u} \cdot (-\mathbf{v}) \\ &= \|\mathbf{u}\|^2 + \|\mathbf{v}\|^2 - 2\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v}.\end{aligned}$$

The two squared distances are equal if and only if $2\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v} = -2\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v}$, which holds if and only if $\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v} = 0$.

Definition. Two vectors $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$ are **orthogonal** (to each other) if and only if _____.

Orthogonal Complements

Definition. If a vector $\mathbf{z}$ is orthogonal to every vector in a subspace W of $\mathbb{R}^n$, then $\mathbf{z}$ is said to be orthogonal to W . The set of all vectors $\mathbf{z}$ that are orthogonal to W is called the **orthogonal complement** of W and is denoted by _____.

Proposition. Let W be a vector subspace.

1. A vector $\mathbf{x}$ is in $W^\perp$ if and only if $\mathbf{x}$ is orthogonal to every vector in a set that spans W .
2. $W^\perp$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Theorem. Let A be an $m \times n$ matrix. Then $(\text{Col } A)^\perp = \text{Nul } A$.

Orthogonal Sets

Definition. A set of vectors $\{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_p\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$ is said to be an **orthogonal set** if each pair of distinct vectors from the set is orthogonal, that is, if $\mathbf{u}_i \cdot \mathbf{u}_j = 0$ whenever $i \neq j$. An orthogonal set is also called **orthonormal set** if every vector in the set is a unit vector.

Theorem. If $S = \{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_p\}$ is an orthogonal set of nonzero vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$, then S is a basis for the subspace spanned by S and hence is an orthogonal basis for the subspace spanned by S .

Definition. An **orthogonal basis** for a subspace W of $\mathbb{R}^n$ is a basis for W that is also an orthogonal set.

Theorem. Let $\{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_p\}$ be an orthogonal basis for a subspace W of $\mathbb{R}^n$. For each $y \in W$, the weights in the linear combination

$$y = c_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + c_p \mathbf{u}_p$$

are given by

$$c_j = \frac{\mathbf{y} \cdot \mathbf{u}_j}{\mathbf{u}_j \cdot \mathbf{u}_j}, \quad j = 1, \dots, p.$$

Orthogonal Projections

Let $\{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_5\}$ be an orthogonal basis for $\mathbb{R}^5$ and let

$$\mathbf{y} = c_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + c_5 \mathbf{u}_5.$$

Consider the subspace $W = \text{Span}\{\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2\}$, and say we want to write $\mathbf{y}$ as the sum of a vector $\mathbf{z}_1$ in W and a vector $\mathbf{z}_2$ in $W^\perp$, that is,

$$\mathbf{y} = \underbrace{c_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + c_2 \mathbf{u}_2}_{\mathbf{z}_1} + \underbrace{c_3 \mathbf{u}_3 + c_4 \mathbf{u}_4 + c_5 \mathbf{u}_5}_{\mathbf{z}_2}$$

where

$$\mathbf{z}_1 = c_1 \mathbf{u}_1 + c_2 \mathbf{u}_2 \quad \text{is in } \text{Span}\{\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2\}$$

and

$$\mathbf{z}_2 = c_3 \mathbf{u}_3 + c_4 \mathbf{u}_4 + c_5 \mathbf{u}_5 \quad \text{is in } \text{Span}\{\mathbf{u}_3, \mathbf{u}_4, \mathbf{u}_5\}.$$

To show that $\mathbf{z}_2$ is in $W^\perp$, it suffices to show that $\mathbf{z}_2$ is orthogonal to the vectors in the basis $\{\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2\}$ for W . Using properties of the inner product, compute

$$\mathbf{z}_2 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1 = (c_3 \mathbf{u}_3 + c_4 \mathbf{u}_4 + c_5 \mathbf{u}_5) \cdot \mathbf{u}_1 = c_3(\mathbf{u}_3 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1) + c_4(\mathbf{u}_4 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1) + c_5(\mathbf{u}_5 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1) = 0$$

because $\mathbf{u}_1$ is orthogonal to $\mathbf{u}_3$, $\mathbf{u}_4$, and $\mathbf{u}_5$. A similar calculation shows that $\mathbf{z}_2 \cdot \mathbf{u}_2 = 0$. Thus $\mathbf{z}_2$ is in $W^\perp$.

Theorem. (The Orthogonal Decomposition Theorem) Let W be a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then each $\mathbf{y}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$ can be written uniquely in the form

$$\mathbf{y} = \hat{\mathbf{y}} + \mathbf{z}$$

where $\hat{\mathbf{y}}$ is in W and $\mathbf{z}$ is in $W^\perp$. In fact, if $\{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_p\}$ is any orthogonal basis of W , then

$$\hat{\mathbf{y}} = \frac{\mathbf{y} \cdot \mathbf{u}_1}{\mathbf{u}_1 \cdot \mathbf{u}_1} \mathbf{u}_1 + \dots + \frac{\mathbf{y} \cdot \mathbf{u}_p}{\mathbf{u}_p \cdot \mathbf{u}_p} \mathbf{u}_p$$

and $\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{y} - \hat{\mathbf{y}}$.

The vector $\hat{\mathbf{y}}$ in the previous equation is called the **orthogonal projection** of y onto W and is often written as $\text{proj}_W \mathbf{y}$.

Proposition. If $\mathbf{y} \in W = \text{Span}\{\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_p\}$, then $\text{proj}_W \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{y}$.

Theorem. (*The Best Approximation Theorem*) Let W be a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$, let $\mathbf{y}$ be any vector in $\mathbb{R}^n$, and let $\hat{\mathbf{y}}$ be the orthogonal projection of $\mathbf{y}$ onto W . Then $\hat{\mathbf{y}}$ is the closest point in W to $\mathbf{y}$, in the sense that

$$\|\mathbf{y} - \hat{\mathbf{y}}\| < \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$$

for all $\mathbf{v}$ in W distinct from $\hat{\mathbf{y}}$.

Example. Let

$$\mathbf{x}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{x}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{x}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Then $\{\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \mathbf{x}_3\}$ is clearly linearly independent and thus is a basis for a subspace W of $\mathbb{R}^4$. To construct an orthogonal basis for W , we use the following process:

Step 1. Let $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{x}_1$ and $W_1 = \text{Span}\{\mathbf{x}_1\} = \text{Span}\{\mathbf{v}_1\}$.

Step 2. Let $\mathbf{v}_2$ be the vector produced by subtracting from $\mathbf{x}_2$ its projection onto the subspace W_1 . That is, let

$$\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{x}_2 - \text{proj}_{W_1} \mathbf{x}_2 = \mathbf{x}_2 - \frac{\mathbf{x}_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1.$$

Since $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{x}_1$,

$$\mathbf{v}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} - \frac{3}{4} \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} -3/4 \\ 1/4 \\ 1/4 \\ 1/4 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Now $\mathbf{v}_2$ is the component of $\mathbf{x}_2$ orthogonal to $\mathbf{x}_1$, and $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2\}$ is an orthogonal basis for the subspace W_2 spanned by $\mathbf{x}_1$ and $\mathbf{x}_2$.

Step 2' (Optional). If appropriate, scale $\mathbf{v}_2$ to simplify later computations. Since $\mathbf{v}_2$ has fractional entries, it is convenient to scale it by a factor of 4 and replace $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2\}$ by the orthogonal basis

$$\mathbf{v}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{v}'_2 = \begin{bmatrix} -3 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Step 3. Let $\mathbf{v}_3$ be the vector produced by subtracting from $\mathbf{x}_3$ its projection onto the subspace W_2 . Use the orthogonal basis $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}'_2\}$ to compute this projection onto W_2 :

$$\text{proj}_{W_2} \mathbf{x}_3 = \frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1 + \frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}'_2}{\mathbf{v}'_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}'_2} \mathbf{v}'_2.$$

Calculating each projection:

$$\frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1 = \frac{2}{4} \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 2/3 \\ 2/3 \\ 2/3 \end{bmatrix},$$

and

$$\frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}'_2}{\mathbf{v}'_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}'_2} \mathbf{v}'_2 = \frac{2}{12} \begin{bmatrix} -3 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

So,

$$\mathbf{v}_3 = \mathbf{x}_3 - \text{proj}_{W_2} \mathbf{x}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} - \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 2/3 \\ 2/3 \\ 2/3 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ -2/3 \\ 1/3 \\ 1/3 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Thus, $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}'_2, \mathbf{v}_3\}$ is an orthogonal set of nonzero vectors, and since W is three-dimensional, by the Basis Theorem, $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}'_2, \mathbf{v}_3\}$ is an orthogonal basis for W .

Theorem. (The Gram-Schmidt Process) Given a basis $\{\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_p\}$ for a nonzero subspace W of $\mathbb{R}^n$, define:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{v}_1 &= \mathbf{x}_1, \\ \mathbf{v}_2 &= \mathbf{x}_2 - \frac{\mathbf{x}_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1, \\ \mathbf{v}_3 &= \mathbf{x}_3 - \frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1 - \frac{\mathbf{x}_3 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2}{\mathbf{v}_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2} \mathbf{v}_2, \\ &\vdots \\ \mathbf{v}_p &= \mathbf{x}_p - \frac{\mathbf{x}_p \cdot \mathbf{v}_1}{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_1} \mathbf{v}_1 - \frac{\mathbf{x}_p \cdot \mathbf{v}_2}{\mathbf{v}_2 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2} \mathbf{v}_2 - \dots - \frac{\mathbf{x}_p \cdot \mathbf{v}_{p-1}}{\mathbf{v}_{p-1} \cdot \mathbf{v}_{p-1}} \mathbf{v}_{p-1}. \end{aligned}$$

Then $\{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_p\}$ is an orthogonal basis for W . In addition,

$$\text{Span}\{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_k\} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} \quad \text{for } 1 \leq k \leq p.$$